their home. They were trained as infantrymen as well as horsemen. The large guns were nominally under the command of Maratha officers. But those who fired and maintained them were mostly Portuguese, French and British.

During the period of the Peshwa Balaji Bajirao, the northern frontiers of the Maratha state were rapidly touching Rajasthan, Delhi and the Punjab. At some point, the Maratha tributary regime extended itself to within fifty miles of Delhi. The Marathas launched raids from Nagpur against Bihar, Bengal and Odisha. Notwithstanding the conflict between the Marathas and the Nizam over Karnataka, Tamil, Kannada and Telugu regions were effectively brought under the control of the Marathas. Between 1745 and 1751 plundering expeditions were launched yearly by the Maratha chieftain Rahuji Bhonsle.

Maratha Administration under Peshwas

The revenue administration of Peshwas was headed by a key official called the Kamavisdar. He was appointed by the Peshwa. He was empowered to maintain a small body of soldiers to police the administrative area, from where tribute or tax had to be collected. A small staff of clerks and servants were employed to maintain the revenue records. These records were randomly checked by the office of the Peshwa. The contracts for revenue collection was auctioned annually after the revenue for a particular place was estimated by the Peshwa's civil servants, based on previous years' yields. A prospective tax or revenue collector who won the contract was expected to have a reputation for wealth and probity. He was required to pay a portion of the whole of the anticipated revenue – one-third to one half – either out of his own wealth or from the money borrowed from bankers. Judging from the ledgers of correspondence and account books, it is evident that the Peshwas were keen on accurate record-keeping. The Peshwa regimes looked distinctly modern in comparison with the Mughals to whose fall they contributed militarily.

The Fall of Marathas

The imperial moment of the Marathas sadly ended at Panipat near Delhi in 1761. The Marathas' attempt to extend their domain beyond Punjab was checked by the king of the Afghans, Ahmad Shah Abdali.



Ahmad Shah Abdali

Abdali invaded eight times before finally marching onto Delhi. The Marathas were now divided among several commanders, who approached the battle with different tactics. Artillery decided the battle in January 1761. The mobile artillery of the Afghans proved lethal against both Maratha cavalry and infantry. The Maratha army was shattered and the surviving men took six months to return to Maharashtra from Panipat to report the tragedy. By then Maratha supremacy over the sub-continent was effectively over.

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